Textual Practice

ISSN: 0950-236X (Print) 1470-1308 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rtpr20

The cultural politics of Canto 49 by Ezra Pound. A historical re-evaluation

Roxana Preda

To cite this article: Roxana Preda (19 Jan 2026): The cultural politics of Canto 49 by Ezra Pound. A historical re-evaluation, Textual Practice, DOI: 10.1080/0950236X.2025.2608849

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/0950236X.2025.2608849

Published online: 19 Jan 2026.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 22

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=rtpr20

TEXTUAL PRACTICE
https://doi.org/10.1080/0950236X.2025.2608849

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Check for updates

The cultural politics of Canto 49 by Ezra Pound. A historical re-evaluation

Roxana Preda

School of English Studies, Sichuan International Studies University, Chongqing, People's Republic of China

ABSTRACT
The critical tradition on Canto 49 by Ezra Pound has consistently privileged its first half, sketching out a Chinese pastoral, whereas the second half has enjoyed much less attention, being treated as more of an appendage than an integral section of the poem. This tradition has thus been unable to reconcile the two sections and give a unified interpretation of the canto. The second half outlines a possible political and historical contextualisation of the first, by integrating the poem more firmly into the ideology of its volume, *The Fifth Decad of Cantos XLII-LI*. It suggests contemporary and impending events around the date of composition (1936), such as Roosevelt's New Deal, the Japanese occupation of Manchuria, the banking reforms in China during its Republican period, as well as the looming Second Sino-Japanese war, events which give the canto an underlying political armature. Detailing and clarifying these issues allows us to reintegrate the snapshot-like nature of our partial understanding into a more unified interpretation and reveals ways in which 49 works as a harbinger of the next section of cantos, devoted to Chinese history more generally (52-61), thus situating it more firmly within Pound's personal investigation into the nature of the twentieth century.

ARTICLE HISTORY Received 11 February 2025; Accepted 1 September 2025

KEYWORDS The Cantos; Ezra Pound; Ernest Fenollosa; the Grand Canal; Guillaume Pauthier; the New Deal; second Sino-Japanese war

1. Ezra Pound's return to Ernest Fenollosa

Ever since its publication as a part of *The Fifth Decad of Cantos* in 1937 (cantos 42-51), number 49, affectionately called 'The Seven Lakes Canto,' has never ceased to fascinate and delight generations of readers. Scholars have returned to it again and again to study its poetic method, its rootedness in the archive, its status as translation, its vital connection to visual art. The parameters of our knowledge about the canto were laid early, in the ground-breaking studies of Achilles Fang, Sanehide Kodama, and Hugh Kenner.[1] Later on, our knowledge has been deepened by the critical edition of

CONTACT Roxana Preda roxanapreda@icloud.com
© 2026 Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

Maria Constanza Ferrero de Luca, and by the more recent interdisciplinary studies of Zhaoming Qian, Hongxin Jiang, and Mark Byron.[2] Canto 49 has been studied very much as a literary collage, a constellation of separate short poems loosely co-existing within the framework of poetic imagination, either as a series of discrete short-poem translations, or as ekphrases, with a strong focus on its first half, in which Pound sketches out in broad strokes a melancholy Chinese pastoral, untouched by politics or history, a realm geared to the seasons in which life is following ancestral patterns, in harmony with the sun and the stars. Pound's source for this dream was a folding book of poems and pictures on the Chinese theme of 'seven lakes', traditionally called *Eight Views of XiaoXiang,* in a Japanese edition owned by his family. A scholar and missionary, Ms. Baosun Zeng, translated the Chinese poems for Pound when she visited Rapallo in 1928.[3] Though the study of the lines shows that Pound worked on Ms. Zeng's crib, his collage of the eight short poems does not give the impression of fragmentation or discontinuity, and can easily be considered as the longest imagist poem Pound ever produced:

> Rain; empty river; a voyage,
> Fire from frozen cloud, heavy rain in the twilight
> Under the cabin roof was one lantern.
> The reeds are heavy; bent;
> and the bamboos speak as if weeping.

This Chinese melancholy paradise was integrated into the logic of *The Cantos* as an Eastern response to earlier pastorals and dreamscapes rooted in the mythology of the West that Pound had included in Cantos 2, 17, and 21. Within the *Fifth Decad*, it also gestures towards an affinity with canto 47 – Pound balances the life of farmers working the land in ancient Greece, who plan their sowing and harvest like a ceremony guided by the stars, to the humble fishermen in the Chinese river and lake regions, living their lives by the water, naturally adjusting to the patterns of seasonal change. Canto 49 eludes a definite answer to the question whether this landscape is real or imaginary: however, scholarship tells us that the 'XiaoXiang' theme, a traditional one in Chinese literary history since the eleventh century, and its associated, newer 'seven lakes' one, really refer to the region around the river Xiang (flowing into Lake Dongting), and its tributary Xiao, near the city of Changsha in Hunan.[4]

The fascination with the beauty of these glimpses of Chinese life so akin to scroll painting, has led scholars to comment much less on the second part of the canto: a few lines suggesting economics spoiled the dream; a quote in Japanese sounded enigmatic and magical but was difficult to integrate with the rest; political echoes seemed somehow inappropriate. In time, with diminished scholarly attention, the second part of the canto has tended to

take the ugly sister role. The second part follows the line 'where the young boys prod stones for shrimp', which marks the end of the first section, based on the poems translated by Ms. Zeng.[5]

A light moves on the north sky line;
where the young boys prod stones for shrimp.
In seventeen hundred came Tsing to these hill lakes.
A light moves on the south sky line.
state by creating riches shd thereby get into debt?
This is infamy; this is Geryon.
This canal goes still to TenShi
though the old king built it for pleasure

K E I M E N R A N K E I
K I U M A N M A N K E I
JITSU GETSU K O K W A
T A N F U K U T A N K A I

Sun up; work
sundown; to rest
dig well and drink of the water
dig field; eat of the grain
Imperial power is? and to us what is it?

The fourth; the dimension of stillness.
And the power over wild beasts.[6]

Despite continued scholarly attention, there are still questions that remain unanswered, and they all concern this second part: a. why is canto 49 included in *The Fifth Decad*, a section of *The Cantos* whose overarching theme is usury? This is even stranger as Pound had not introduced any Chinese material into his poem since canto 13, finalised in 1923, 13 years before; b. Why did Pound suddenly introduce the 'Geryon' motif, recontextualising a Greek monster figure reinterpreted by Dante Alighieri to China? c. What is the implication of the theme of civil works such as the Grand Canal in the poem, and why is imperial intervention introduced at all? And finally, d. why did Pound decide to include an old Chinese poem in Japanese transcription into this context? The canto deals with Chinese landscapes, Chinese poetic traditions, even Chinese civil works. Why did Pound overcomplicate this with a Japanese overlay?

The starting point at elucidating these questions will need to be the scene of composition: unlike the first part of the canto, which relies on material Pound had had from 1928, the second part was created from scratch sometime in 1936: to judge by Pound's letters, in the fall. He wrote to James Laughlin on 17 September, 1936: 'Have shipped the three Sienese Cantos, and have a fourth pretty well set. but a few hunks of Orient and Adonis cult already drafted must intervene.'[7] In these short sentences, we get

valuable information not only about canto 49, unfinished at the time, but also about its position vis-a-vis cantos 42-44, on the bank Monte dei Paschi in Siena, which had just been completed, as well as on canto 50, on Napoleon Bonaparte, which was nearly ready. Pound does not say how developed the draft is; however, by 30 October, he had the whole *Fifth Decad* ready, as he wrote to Olga Rudge, referring to himself as usual in the third person: 'He has typed out some sort of a draft fer the rest of 42/51'.[8] Pound sent her all the finished typescripts with the letter. Looking at these traces, our conclusion must be that Pound finalised the canto from the latter half of September to late October 1936. He worked on the crib provided by Ms Zeng for the first part and found his way back to Ernest Fenollosa's manuscripts for the second one.[9] That return made sense in this special situation, as these manuscripts were Pound's personal archive of Chinese classical poems, which he could use to supplement the ones around 'the seven lakes' in the first part. However, it is worth pointing out that Pound had not introduced any quotes from Chinese poems into *The Cantos* since canto 4, written in 1919.[10] Throughout the 1920s and 1930s, he had turned his attention to the Confucian philosophy classics, rather than to China's poetic tradition.

The composition of the canto may also have had to do with Pound's editorial activities of 1936, particularly with his decision to initiate the so-called 'Ideogramic Series' with the London publisher Stanley Nott. Pound was able to republish Fenollosa's essay, 'The Chinese Written Character as a Medium for Poetry' in March, and the *Ta Hio* (*Daxue*, 'The Great Digest') in May 1936. The poet was coming back to the Chinese classics through his collateral publications. This return is significant, as Pound had chosen to distance himself from Fenollosa when dealing with Chinese sources. Throughout the 1920s and 1930s, he had used the work of French sinologists, especially Alexandre Lacharme and Guillaume Pauthier as mediators of Chinese culture,[11] and continued to use them afterward. He returned to Fenollosa just for this canto, a fact which is individual to it, as it arguably bears an essential ideological affinity to Fenollosa's ideas about the cultures of the East. My working hypothesis is that Pound did not conceive the canto as a sort of retreat from history into a pastoral shaped by the aesthetics of Chinese art, but rather as a veiled political inquiry suggested by a concrete historical situation. Much as it pains us, the beauty of the canto's first part may conceivably be not the essence but the stage-set of a political reflection whose result might prove to be dangerous, even unbearable. The sense of order which had been ensured by the imperial regime of power until 1912 was threatened by economic and financial developments in the republican era as well as by imbalances in China's relation to Japan. We know that Pound was informed of the Japanese occupation of Manchuria because he had introduced the theme of Japanese rearmament in canto 38. The threat

of a second war between these two countries was looming large in the autumn of 1936.

2. Canto 49 and *The Fifth Decad*. Questions of composition

If we consider The *Fifth Decad* (cantos 42-51, published in 1937) in more detail, we might observe that this is a poem suite converging around the idea of usury. At its centre, we find the first cantos in the order of publication, 45 and 46, which are both strongly about the subject.[12] Pound's work as a whole seems to indicate that he understood the term 'usury' in broad terms as the economic system of liberalism, founded on the idea of free market, call it the 'economy of debt', mostly prevalent in the Western geopolitical sphere. This idea is indicated by his locating the origin of usury in the creation of the Bank of England in 1694, and particularly in its use of fiat money. Pound positioned this historical event in canto 46, at the very centre of *The Fifth Decad*. Across the sequence, he delineated various forces that could possibly counteract usury: in cantos 42 and 43, it is a bank in Siena, the Monte dei Paschi, owned by the city, whose low-interest loans helped local business, and whose income was guaranteed by public revenue from grassland outside town; in canto 45, it is art produced outside market forces, which by its reliance on skill and invention is also a protest against an industrial economics demanding the cheap, mass-produced product; in cantos 47 and 49, it is a self-sustaining agricultural way of life, set by ancestral rules and unmoved since the beginning of history; in cantos 44 and 50, Pound even investigates whether imperial power like that of Napoleon might be an anti-usury force, which by military conquest also sweeps away historical accretions of traditional political and economic arrangements. Pound's correspondence with Robert McNair Wilson, an author specialised in Napoleon's character and career, thematised the idea that Bonaparte had been an anti-usury force that was destroyed by the collusion of the monarchic families across Europe with the Rothschild banking empire.[13]

This environment suggests that canto 49 is positioned as an argument against liberal economy, made against the background of the Chinese pastoral paradise. Arguably, the poet's outburst against Geryon as a symbol of monstrous fraud signals a submerged economics that hinges on the relation between the liberal economies of debt and state power, as channelled into and manifested in civil works. This becomes clearer when we consider the historical situation of Republican China, the period between the fall of the Qing dynasty in 1912 and the Communist assumption of power in 1949. This was certainly a period of high political instability: the state was fragmented among regional warlords; nationalists and communists were disputing power in a civil war; starting with 1931, the Japanese were taking root in

Manchuria and were dangerously connected by railways to the major cities like Beijing and Shanghai. Apart from that, British, American, and French concessions in Shanghai in the so-called 'International Settlement' were creating zones of economic and political autonomy modelled on liberal economies on Chinese territory. The British and American zone was a state within a state; not only did it allow and protect banking institutions modelled on the West but had powers of taxation and law enforcement within the area.[14] To a contemporary observer interested in economics, as Pound was, the Chinese space was a field contested between an emerging liberal financial system modelled on the West and the old traditional form of imperial power that China had had until 1912. The nationalist party, the Kuomintang, led by Chiang Kai Scheck, had very strong ties with American investment in the Shanghai Settlement zone through his family, that of the self-made millionaire, Charlie Soong. Pound's opinions about Chiang and his ties with American economic liberalism surfaced rather bluntly in his later radio broadcasts, where he berated the Chinese leader for turning his back on native Confucian traditions and adopting foreign, speak, American economic views and practices that in Pound's view harmed rather than helped China:

> Order at home. China with 400 millions IN ORDER would indeed be an element for world stability. But that order must RISE IN CHINA. In 300 or more years of history, in fact in all the history we have of that country, the order must rise inside. At no time has China been at peace in the hands of a government run from outside on loan capital. […] Foreign loan capital is NO substitute for the tradition of Wen and Wu, for the lesson of pre-Christian dynasties.[15]

In canto 49, Pound documents his preference for the old imperial system by referring obliquely to one of the oldest, still existing monuments of civil engineering, the Grand Canal of China, pointing out that 'the old king' (Yang of Sui, r. 604–618 AD) 'built it for pleasure'. Looking more carefully at the phrase, which is in itself eccentric, we might rephrase it to mean that the old king built the canal as his property for imperial use. It was a work that belonged to him, hence to the state and the people, who used it to transport goods from south to north. Taking Pound's distinction between property and capital, first made in his *ABC of Economics* (1933), we might understand the statement 'built for (imperial) pleasure' to mean that public works like the Chinese canal were public *property*, not *capital*, i.e. a form of investment:

> I shall use the term property as distinct from the term capital.
> 'Capital' for the duration of this treatise implies a sort of claim on others, a sort of right to make others work. Property does not.
> For example. My bust by Gaudier is my property. Nobody is expected to do anything about it.

> My bond of the X and Y railroad is capital. Somebody is supposed to earn at least 60 dollars a year and pay it to me because I own such a bond. Therefore: it would be possible to attack the 'rights' or 'privileges' of capital without attacking the rights or privileges of property.[16]

This distinction, crucial to Pound, since it was made on the first page of the *ABC*, can usefully be translated today into our understanding of modern infrastructure. When a road is built as public property, it is maintained out of the general public purse and does not require citizens to pay a toll to use it. When it is built as a form of investment, then the investor, be he the representative of a state agency, or an individual entrepreneur, will take out loans from banks, build the road, and require tolls from users on a rolling basis to recoup expenses, pay back the loan, and earn profit. Pound's question in the canto: 'state by creating riches shd thereby get into debt?' has thus a general relevance, referring not only to the Chinese situation, but also to the European and American ones in 1936, at a time when major infrastructure works were being carried out. In canto 38, Pound had considered the Italian 'bonifica' project, which involved draining the swamps of Lazio and Tuscany, to turn them into arable land (1928-1939); in Germany, it was the network of quality roads designed for the automobile (the Reichsautobahn system, 1933-1941); but more than these, Pound had in mind F. D. Roosevelt's programme of civil works under the umbrella of the Public Works Administration – unlike the European projects, which were funded by the state, in the US, only approximately 30% was financed by Congress appropriation, the rest allowed private enterprise to funnel loans and investment into roads, bridges, airports, and electrification.[17] Considering China's case, Pound thus compared the old imperial understanding of civil works with the liberal way of conceiving them, something which is evident in the drafts published in *Posthumous Cantos*, where the submerged connection is evident:

> That the state by creating riches
> shd thereby run into debt
> This is infamy, this is Geryon.
> That the state in making a city, shd. run into debt to
> privati, to Johnson and Bernstein, this is an infamy;
> that you shd. send food abroad before feeding your people
> this is Geryon, this is an infamy[18]

Pound's decision to cut the line about Johnson and Bernstein was meant to anchor the statement about state creating riches more strongly within the Chinese context. Creating a clear parallel to European and American public works, which were current in 1936, would have diluted and dispersed the focus Pound wanted to put on the Chinese situation. Moreover, Pound's economic correspondence indicates that he deeply resented the funding

methods of the New Deal (whereby the American government did indeed get indebted to private persons to create infrastructure). However, these collateral suggestions remain crucial in understanding why the theme of civil works was introduced into the canto under the sign of Geryon, Dante Alighieri's demon of fraud.

The theme of the canal, as a political and economic foil to the natural beauty of the river landscape in the canto's first part, is taken further in Pound's almost casual line 'In seventeen hundred came Tsing to these hill lakes'. The passage suggests that imperial power is light touch and does not affect the agricultural paradise in the remote provinces, since the Qing dynasty had been established in the faraway Tenshi (the city of the emperor, i.e. the capital) more than fifty years before. However, here too, we are faced with some enigmas. The first concerns the unusual spelling of the dynasty name: 'Tsing' is definitely not a Wade/Giles notation: it is a French romanisation, a fact noticed early by Sanehide Kodama.[19] However, he erroneously assumed that Pound already owned the volumes of the *Histoire générale de la Chine* by Jacques de Mailla and was referencing them. We know that this could not have been the case, as in 1936, Pound had not yet bought the book. We can date his purchase very accurately in November 1937, a year later than the canto composition.

Pound had a French source for the Qing emperors' visits to these lakes, namely Guillaume Pauthier's *Chine moderne ou Description historique, géographique et littéraire de ce vaste empire* (Paris, 1847), where the name is spelled 'Thsing' – Pound may have dropped the 'h' it to adapt it to English pronunciation. This work in two volumes belonged to Pound's personal library: Tim Redman, who catalogued it, indicated that the first volume, the historical one by Pauthier, was heavily marked.[20] Pound would use this source again in *Guide to Kulchur*, which he wrote in March 1937, roughly five months after the canto. In his chapter, 'Kung', Pound gave examples of social legislation during the Tang dynasty that can be directly traced back to Pauthier and are witness that he had a good foundation in Chinese history which underlies canto 49, and was almost two years prior to the composition of the Chinese History cantos (52-61) in 1938. Pound found out about Mailla's *Histoire generale* in Pauthier, who referenced this source frequently.

Pauthier does mention the visit of the Qing emperors to the South in a way that binds them more strongly with the theme of public works. Kangxi Emperor made trips in 1684-5, 1689, 1699, 1704, 1705 and 1707; his grandson, Qianlong, personally inspected the canals in 1751, 1757, 1762, 1765, 1780 and 1784. Here is how Kangxi sums up his imperial responsibility vis-à-vis them:

> I did not dare spend uselessly the treasures of the empire, whose protection is entrusted to the court of tributes: this is the blood of the people. I only

> allocated what was necessary for the subsistence of the armies and survival from famines. I never allowed that silks be hung in the apartments of the houses where I stayed during my travels throughout the empire; and the expenditure in each place did not go over 10–20 thousand ounces of silver (75,000 or 150 000 francs). If we consider that I disbursed annually more than three million ounces of silver for the maintenance and repairs of embankments, we can see that the above expense does not go up to even a hundredth part of this.[21]

The emperors visited the south because they wanted to ensure the maintenance and repair of the canals, which since their construction around 1000 years earlier in the Sui dynasty, had become a treasure the nation could not do without. Pound suggests that the Qing emperors made the visits to the canal 'for pleasure' in the same way that the 'old king' had built it for pleasure, as a manifestation of the monarch's discretionary power, as an instantiation of his will, initiative and responsibility[22] – the emperors maintained the national heritage of the country, in the same way that Emperor Yang of Sui created the canal not for his personal recreation but as a personal project to improve the public transportation of grain from the south to the north. We see then that Pound's economic orientation here takes on a definite Social Credit colouring. The emperors were creating wealth meant for centuries. They had a distributive approach to national assets which were orientated towards the public good, since the canal was national heritage that needed to be protected and maintained; it created a permanent 'national dividend' to the country by encouraging association, trade, and distribution of resources. The continuity of the imperial system over centuries ensured that work done a millennium before would be inherited, managed, and cared for by successive emperors as 'pleasure', i.e. as a personalised government responsibility, much as Kangxi's Testament attests.

3. The Japanese message

If this understanding of power in the imperial era is granted, it is then imperative to look again at the four lines in Japanese that Pound chose to insert into the poem. For every person unfamiliar with the language, these four lines are an oasis of mystery, possibly a sort of mantra responding to the exoticism of the first section of the canto. This method of inserting a space of darkness and mystery into the cantos by using a foreign language was not a new procedure: Pound tried it out first in canto 23, where he included a few lines from the poet Stesichorus in the Greek original, interspersing them with their Latin translation. We find another example in canto 39, in the secret message that Circe tells Odysseus in the dark – five lines from the tenth canto of the *Odyssey* in the original Greek. The technique occurs again in an enigmatic classical Chinese quotation written vertically in canto 55. All these instances past and future indicate a poetic

method, and the best way to understand it is to briefly return to the first time it was used, in canto 23. If we understand its rationale there, we might be within our rights to infer that the purpose of the procedure is the same in canto 49.

Canto 23 is devoted to an understanding of the Greek heritage of European modernity and of the ways it manifested itself at various times, especially in France. It starts with the following strong statement: 'Never with this religion/ will you make men of the Greeks' (23/ 107). The person speaking is the Byzantine philosopher Gemistos Plethon, the religion he refers to is Christianity, and the time is shortly before the Byzantine empire fell to the Ottomans. Rather than trust in God, Plethon says, Greeks need to construct a wall across the isthmus of Corinth to defend against the invaders. Building a wall is of course the opposite of what a Christian would do, namely withdraw into the sanctuary of a church, pray fervently, and hope that God will protect and save. Pound suggests in canto 23 that Plethon's no nonsense, vigorous, and courageous practicality is part of the pagan Greek inheritance that was forgotten during the Christian era but resurfaced during modernity, in the matter-of-fact way in which scientists not only innovated and researched, but took personal risk and sacrifice in stride, whether this risk was taking in huge amount of radiation, or being exposed to viral agents in a lab accident:

> […] 'J'ai
> Obtenu une brulure' M. Curie, or some other scientist
> 'Qui m'a coûté six mois de guérison.'
> and continued his experiments. (23/108)

The lines from Stesichorus seem to offer an archetypal narrative dramatising Pound's meaning: they recount that Helios, the sun god, disappears from view during the night: he floats in a golden cup to the other end of Okeanos to be with his wife and children in a laurel grove. He takes a rest there like mortals do, and then reappears on the sky at dawn. We see therefore how the few lines of Stesichorus create an allegory for the way in which Greek cultural power, taken for granted as sunlight in the pagan antiquity, gradually becomes invisible under the impact of Christianity but re-emerges after centuries within modernity, when the Christian religious wave has subsided. The conclusion we might draw on Pound's general method is more radical: the key to understanding the canto, the most important metaphor that controls it as a poetic unit, is locked away behind unfamiliar allegories and the screen of a language we don't know. If we skip the foreign language quote, chances are high that we have not understood what holds the canto together and the poem remains a heap of unrelated fragments. The situation is similar in the other instances, cantos 39 and 55. The choice of the magic language is not arbitrary either but has to do with

the cultural context of the canto – Greek and Latin for 23, Greek for 39, and Chinese for 55. Therefore, following this reasoning, we are within our rights to conclude that in canto 49, the pivot of the poem rests in the lines written in Japanese. Understanding the rationale of these would be key in putting the two halves of the canto together.

So … why Japanese here? It is essential to know that the lines are a transliteration of an ancient Chinese poem about government called 'Auspicious Clouds.' The original is included in the Shangshu dazhuan (Zh. 尚書大傳, Commentary to the *Book of Documents* by Fu Sheng (200-100 BC)). The author imagines the poem to be sung by Emperor Shun (2294-2184 BC) when he announced that his successor would not be his own son but the man who had solved the problem of the country's flooding, Yu the Great (2123–2025 BC). The lyrics celebrate someone who willingly passed government control to the best qualified person, and this person's merit lies in the control of the waters – here we have another avatar of the canal idea. The greatest service a person can do to his country is to control the waters, channel them for agriculture and distribution of resources across the country.

We might be within our rights to ask: if Pound wanted to lock away a personal unifying statement behind a foreign language, why didn't he choose the original Chinese? We might think of three answers to this question. The first and the simplest is that he did not have the Chinese original at hand; he only had the Japanese transliteration in Fenollosa's papers. Fenollosa had taken a course of Chinese poetry with Professor Kainan Mori, in 1901. Mori explained the ancient poem and provided a translation in Japanese. As the papers show, an English crib was created at the time with the help of an assistant. However, in view of the poet's earlier methods, this reason seems insufficient: with other cantos, Pound verified his sources, researched in the archive himself, and read hundreds of pages of source material to distill his text. It is unlikely that in this instance, he would uncharacteristically take the easy way out.

As a second hypothesis, we might take the view that Pound could have been inspired by Ernest Fenollosa's position on the relationship between China and Japan in his essay *The Chinese Written Character as a Medium for Poetry*, which Pound had reprinted a few months before with the London publisher Stanley Nott. While bemoaning the European and American cultural racism concerning the Far East, Fenollosa, writing in the wake of the first Sino-Japanese War of 1895, asserted his own position, deriving from a Japanese point of view, namely that

> Several centuries ago, China lost much of her creative self, and of her insight into the causes of her own life, but her original spirit still lives, grows, interprets, transferred to Japan in all its original freshness.[23]

Fenollosa was persuaded that Japan had been the crucial preserver and transmitter of Chinese culture to modernity. In his view, China had lost the meaning and purpose of its own culture: the merit of preserving it lay in the Japanese creativity as well as channels of education and publication. In this second reading, then, the classical Chinese poem comes down to us courtesy of Japan, which conserved Chinese cultural patrimony, in a role similar to that of Latin vis-à-vis the ancient Greek culture in Europe. Thus, a second, more innocent reading of the Japanese transliteration would be that Pound agreed with Fenollosa (at least to a certain extent) that ancient Chinese culture was mediated by Japanese – it was no accident that he had himself first encountered it in this way, via an American scholar who had made his career in Japan, or that the first part of the canto had its source in a bilingual edition of poems and landscapes on the Chinese classical theme of the 'seven lakes,' published in Japan. Moreover, as Hugh Kenner noted, Pound used only the Japanese sounds, 'transcribed as accurately as the handwriting would permit. Fenollosa had suggested that Japanese sounds kept the archaic Chinese pronunciation better than modern Mandarin'[24] – a very pro-Japanese twist on Fenollosa's part, indeed.

Yet, there is a third, more troubling reading that we might consider. 'Auspicious Clouds', the poem transcribed in Japanese, could at first glance be innocently subsumed under the same landscape poetry genre that governed he first part of the canto.

卿雲爛兮	KEI WUN RAN KEI	The auspicious clouds are vivid!
糺縵縵兮	KIU MAN MAN KEI	Gathered together they circle around!
日月光華，	JITSU GETSU K O KWA	The sun and moon have brightness and splendour,
旦復旦兮	TAN FUKU TAN KEI	Returning dawn after dawn![25]

Yet Among Fenollosa's papers, Pound found not only the transliteration and crib but also Prof. Mori's allegorical reading: 'The moral of the poem is that ministers working in harmony, as the sun & moon, will enable the state to preserve its glory forever. Sun and moon refer to officials. Clouds represent the world – society in general. Succession of sun & moon may refer to imperial succession.'[26] The lines in Japanese transcription thus speak about something even more important than economics – of the best way to govern, saying that going from one regime of power to another should be like the sun and moon following each other naturally every day – they won't affect life on the ground. The Japanese overlay of the poem in effect suggests that if a Japanese, rather than a Chinese form of government is more meritorious, why not allow it? The Qing, a Manchu tribe from the north-east had ruled China for three centuries. There were certain parallels between a

Manchu and a potential Japanese conqueror, visible to Pound in 1936: both come from relatively small territories, yet manage to control politically a much larger country in decline; both invade from Manchuria in the north-east; both attack swiftly and come to control the centre of power fast. The visit of the Qing emperor to the south is thus not there simply to imply that the lake region is too remote even for the imperial power; it is to suggest a possible parallel between the Manchu conquest of 1644 and a Japanese one, still in the future.

Returning to the magical lines, we also find out that this is no accidental poem but China's most powerful political song. Indeed, the poem was so important that it served as the Chinese national anthem during the Revolutionary era, more particularly after the fall of the Qing dynasty, from 1913-1915, and later, 1921-1928. The anthem was again used by collaborationists during the Second Sino-Japanese War.[27] When trying to contact Pound for the first time in 1950, Achilles Fang joked about it to James Laughlin: Fang assumed Pound did not know he had struck such gold.[28] However, this potential issue opens possibilities for the interpretation of the poem. Did Pound know that this was the Chinese national anthem? If Pound did not know, we might rest with what could be called the second reading: Japanese is used because it is a transmitter of Chinese culture, the ancient song comes to Pound via Japanese cultural structures like translation and publishing, in the same way that in Europe, Greek patrimony is mediated by Latin into modern times. But if Pound knew that this was China's most potent political song, the equation changes quite dramatically. Singing this political anthem in Japanese would adumbrate the conquest of China by Japan, a thought which in retrospect and from our present perch we certainly find intolerable but with which Fenollosa would have agreed as a sort of cultural apotheosis. The song affirms that succession to political power should fall to the most meritorious and is as smooth and fine as day following day. The Japanese had nested themselves in Manchuria, the ancestral land of the Qing emperors; they were to invade and conquer China in the same way the Qing did. There was a minor inconvenience that the capital of China in 1936 was in Nanjing, not Beijing, thus much farther away from the Northern border. The Japanese would have to travel more – on the other hand, they had railways and airplanes. It was possible for an intellectual in 1936, who had even a superficial knowledge of Chinese history, to assume that from their privileged position in Manchuria, the Japanese were going to attempt a conquest as smooth and fast as that of the Manchus in 1644. For Pound, this had the added interest that the Japanese might destroy Chiang Kai Scheck's Americanised conception of republic. The magical incantation of the Japanese lines suggests that such a political takeover would not affect the Chinese ancestral paradise and even possibly protect it from afar. We might even push further to say that Pound's outburst about Geryon might be an allusion to

contemporary economic processes in China and refer to the Republican attempts to 'modernise,' speak Americanise Chinese banking as it was channeled into civil works. In view of his Social Credit economics, Pound could well fear that this might affect not only the old Confucian political system but the paradise he evoked in the first part of the poem.

If we follow this thread, Pound seems to tell us that it is not important if the form of government is Chinese or Japanese, as it won't affect the ancestral agricultural way of life in China. This is a difficult view to contemplate but will need to come into our equation if we want to reconstruct Pound's thought about the political situation in these two countries, at a time when military conflict between them was imminent.

4. Concluding and looking ahead

By contextualising Canto 49 in both its year of composition and the historical moment, we are thus able to see the poem not simply in literary terms, but as a diptych comprised of idyll and political reflection. The canto ends in the enigmatic couplet: 'Fourth: the dimension of stillness/ And the power over wild beasts', conjoining its two parts to suggest that for the dimension of stillness to exist, the dominion over brutality and destruction must also exist. Pound mentions the imperial power, which had guarded the pastoral life from the intrusion of modern liberal economics of debt, and created the distributive dimension of wealth sharing through the canal. The poem's enigmatic message, encoding an ancient Chinese political poem into Japanese, can be understood as a meditation on the definitive replacement of this regime of power – not by a vulnerable and unstable republic but by empire, through a second Sino-Japanese war which had not broken out yet in the fall of 1936, but was looming and threatening while still a potential. The Japanese would attack China in July 1937, less than 10 months after the canto was written. Pound's reaction in the autumn of that year was to refer to the conflict as 'the unusual idiocy of the Japanese invasion'.[29] It strongly suggests that he had chosen an answer to the question of the possible merits of a Japanese military conquest, or even of a predominance in cultural matters. It was one thing to reflect during peacetime on the possible merits of Japan as a 'saviour' of China, and quite another to be confronted with the horrors of actual war reality. While the Japanese were ransacking and terrorising Nanjing in November 1937, in a sort of desperate intellectual doubling down, Pound purchased the eleven volumes of Jacques de Mailla's *Histoire générale de la Chine* and dedicated the whole year of 1938 to writing ten cantos about the Chinese classical political culture and imperial history while the Japanese invasion was raging on. The composition of these cantos (52-61) was a study of the Chinese historical process along centuries and offered the careful student a virtual prognosis of contemporary events.

Surveying historical precedent, Pound would have seen that neither the colonial intrusion of French, American, and British forces, nor the outright military conquest of the Japanese would take hold. It is by writing the cantos dedicated to Chinese history that Pound could respond to and resolve the intellectual temptation suggested in Canto 49, that Japanese culture could continue to function as an archive and medium of transmission of the Chinese one. Canto 49 inaugurates Pound's definitive break with the idea of a Japanese mediation, which had been so strong in his youth. Henceforth, he would study Chinese history, writing, and philosophy on its own terms, and separate himself from his education by Fenollosa forever.

Credit line

Quotes from the works of Ezra Pound used by permission of New Directions, agent for the Ezra Pound heirs.

Notes

1. Achilles Fang, 'Fenollosa and Pound', *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies*, 20 (1957), 213–238; Hugh Kenner, 'More on the Seven Lakes Canto', *Paideuma* 2 (1973), 43–6; Sanehide Kodama, 'The Eight Scenes of Sho-Sho', *Paideuma* 6 (1977), 131–45.
2. Maria Costanza Ferrero De Luca (ed.), *Ezra Pound e il Canto dei Sette Laghi* (Diabasis, 2004); Zhaoming Qian, 'Painting into Poetry: Pound's Seven Lakes Canto' *Ezra Pound and China,* ed. Zhaoming Qian (Michigan, 2003), 72–95; Hongxin Jiang, 'Painting and Poetry: Ezra Pound's 'Seven Lakes Canto' and Eight Views of Xiao Xiang' *Revista Brasileira de Literatura Comparada* 22 (2020), 84–94; Mark Byron, 'Ezra Pound's 'Seven Lakes' Canto: Poetry and Painting, from East to West', *The Rikkyo Review: Arts & Letters* 73 (2013), 121–142.
3. See the folding book at Roxana Preda (ed.), *The Cantos Project*: *XLIX – Sources* (publ. online July 2020) <https://ezrapoundcantos.org/canto-xlix/xlix-sources> accessed 18 December 2025. See also Zhaoming Qian, 'Why Is Canto 49 Called The "Seven Lakes Canto"'? *Paideuma* 43 (2016): 191–98, for the significance of Ms. Zeng as first translator of the poems.
4. Qian, 2016, 194. See also Alfreda Murck, 'The 'Eight Views of Xiao-Xiang' and the Northern Song Culture of Exile', *Journal of Song-Yuan Studies*, 26 (1996): 113–144.
5. See full canto at *Poetry Archive* <https://poetryarchive.org/poem/canto-49/> accessed 15 December 2024.
6. Ezra Pound, *The Cantos* (New Directions, 1998), 245. Henceforth marked as canto no/page no.
7. *Pound/Laughlin. Selected Letters*, ed. David M. Gordon (Norton, 1994), 65; Mike Malm, *Editing Economic History: Ezra Pound's The Fifth Decad of Cantos* (Peter Lang, 2005), 279.
8. Beinecke Library, New Haven, Olga Rudge Papers, YCAL 54, Box 17, Folder 447.

9. Pound was gifted Ernest Fenollosa's archive by his widow in 1913-1914. Since Fenollosa had taken a course on Chinese literature with Prof. Kainan Mori in 1901, these papers also included cribs of classical Chinese poems.
10. Pound references Wang Wei's 'The Song of the Peach Blossom Fountain' and Song Yu's 'Rhapsody on the Wind' in canto 4, which was first published at Ovid Press in London, in 1919.
11. Alexander Lacharme (ed. and trans.), *Confucii Chi-King Sive Liber Carminum* [The Shijing of Confucius, or the Book of Poems], (Julius Mohl, 1830) and Guillaume Pauthier (ed. and trans.), *Doctrine de Confucius*: *Les Quatre livres de philosophie morale et politique de la Chine* (Garnier, 1814).
12. Canto 45 was ready by 3 December 1935, as documented by Pound's letter to James Laughlin on that day. Canto 46 was sent to Laughlin on 31 January 1936 for publication in the New York paper *New Democracy*. It was printed there in March 1936. See letters in Roxana Preda (ed.), *The Cantos Project: Calendars of Composition* to cantos 45 and 46, <https://ezrapoundcantos.org/canto-xlv?start=3> and https://ezrapoundcantos.org/canto-xlvi?start=3, accessed 10 December 2024 and https://ezrapoundcantos.org/canto-xlvi?start=3, accessed 18 December 2025.
13. See Robert McNair Wilson, *Napoleon the Man* (1927); *The Mind of Napoleon* (1934); *Promise to Pay. An Inquiry into the Modern Magic Called High Finance* (1934). Pound corresponded with McNair Wilson from 1934 to 1959. See letters in the Beinecke Library, https://archives.yale.edu/repositories/11/archival_objects/2388951, accessed 10 December 2024.
14. 'Shanghai's special status had long attracted what were to become some of the world's premium Western banking institutions, such as HSBC and Chartered Bank. But modern Chinese banks, which only began operating from the end of the 19th century, also found homes there. In particular, the jurisdictional autonomy established by the Settlement sheltered the Bank of China's Shanghai branch from the Beijing government's ruinous fiscal demands in 1916, highlighting the value of independence. Even China's traditional family-owned native banks increasingly chose to locate inside the Settlement. The relocation of the Shanghai Native Bankers' Association from the Chinese portion of the city to within the Settlement area in 1917, followed by the founding of the association of modern Chinese banks in 1918, marked the rise of Shanghai's Chinese banking community as the leading force in China's macroeconomy, monetary, and financial regulation within a freebanking framework'. Debin Ma, 'Financial revolution in Republican China, 1900-1937: A Survey and Interpretation', *VoxEu* Columns (publ. online 4 June 2019) <https://cepr.org/voxeu/columns/financial-revolution-republican-china-1900-1937-survey-and-interpretation> accessed 30 December 2024.
15. Ezra Pound, *Radio Speeches of WW II,* #79, April 24, 1943 (Greenwood Press, 1978). See also Pound's negative attitude to Chiang Kai Scheck, as documented in his radio broadcasts of 1941: 'You could get more enthusiasm out of those Chinks for a Hot Dog Championship on the Northside than you could for Chiang's FOREIGN party in China. A LOT of China is NOT pro-Kai-Chek. A lot of China is NOT FOR that gang of foreign investors.' *Radio Speeches*, #1, October 2, 1941.
16. Ezra Pound, *ABC of Economics* (Faber, 1933), 13-14.

17. See 'Reichsautobahn' at <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Reichsautobahn>; Carl T. Schmidt, 'Land Reclamation in Fascist Italy.' *Political Science Quarterly* 52 (1937), 340–63; F. D. Roosevelt, 'The New Deal', <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/New_Deal> accessed 23 December 2024.
18. Massimo Bacigalupo (ed.), Ezra Pound, *Posthumous Cantos* (Carcanet, 2015), 44.
19. Kodama, 'The Eight Scenes of Sho-Sho', 140.
20. Tim Redman, 'Pound's Library: A Preliminary Catalog', *Paideuma: Modern and Contemporary Poetry and Poetics*, 15 (1986), 231.
21. Testament of Emperor Kangxi in G. Pauthier. *L'Univers. Chine ou Description historique, géographique et littéraire de ce vaste empire* (Garnier, 1847), 440. [My translation]. Digital copy in the collections of the Bibliothèque nationale, <https://gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/bpt6k30784c> accessed 30 December 2024.
22. 'At His Majesty's Pleasure', UOLLB, 6 July 2024 <https://uollb.com/blogs/uol/at-his-majestys-pleasure> accessed 25 August 2025.
23. Ezra Pound, *Instigations. Together with an Essay on the Chinese Written Character by Ernest Fenollosa* (Boni and Liveright, 1920), 360.
24. Kenner 46.
25. See the poem 'Auspicious Clouds' in the Chinese original at Roxana Preda (ed.), *The Cantos Project*: *Sources to XLIX* (pubd July 2020) <https://ezrapoundcantos.org/canto-xlix/xlix-sources> accessed 20 December 2024. Translation by Kent Su.
26. Quoted in Kenner 46.
27. See 'Song to the Auspicious Clouds', at https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Song_to_the_Auspicious_Cloud accessed 20 December 2024.
28. From Achilles Fang to James Laughlin, 31 May 1950: 'P.S. I am sending you photostatic copy of Auspicious Clouds song. Here's why:

    From Robert Payne's article in World Review (1949) I gather that Mr. Pound is given to declaiming Chinese Odes. I wonder if he would like to sing the national anthem of China under the First Republic, if only to break the intolerable monotony of St. Elizabeth's. The text of the anthem is the Auspicious Clouds song (k'ing yu ko) of the emperor Shun:

    k'ing (auspicious) yun (clouds) lan (bright) hi (expletive)
    kiu (gathered) man (in mass) man (in mass) hi
    jih (sun) yueh (moon) kuang (luminous) hua (brilliant)
    tan (dawn) fu (again) tan (dawn) hi

    (in James Legge's free version: Splendid are the clouds and bright/ All aglow with various light!/ grand the sun and moon move on;/ Daily dawn succeeds to dawn.)

    This song is as much Mr. Pound's as anybody else's, for he has incorporated it into Canto 49. The outlandish quatrain there is Japanese transcription (from Fenollosa Mss.?) of this song. (Unfortunately misprinted: MEN should read WUN or UN and KAI should have been printed KEI.) I doubt if any Chinese scholar will recognize the quatrain, for he is usually unfamiliar with Japanese pronunciation of Chinese characters; for that matter, few Japanese scholars will recognize it either, for the song is quite alien to them.

If you think Mr. Pound's present state of mind can stand 'shock of recognition', would you please forward the enclosed song with or without the attached sheet.' *Pound/Laughlin. Selected Letters*, 205.

29. Ezra Pound, 'Mang-Tsze' in *Selected Prose* (New Directions, 1973), 95.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author.